ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · June 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	79.7
#2	A+	Charlotte	74.2
#3	A+	Kansas City	73.5
#4	A+	Atlanta	71.5
#5	A+	Nashville	69.0
#6	A+	Cincinnati	68.2
#7	A	Hartford	67.8

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Jacksonville	19.3
#49	C-	Louisville	26.3
#48	C-	Grand Rapids	30.4
#47	C-	Detroit	31.7
#46	C	Richmond	32.4
#45	C	Portland	33.1
#44	C	Minneapolis	33.2

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	23 cities
C+ / C / C-	16 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · June 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A+	79.7	3.0%	+4.2%	+2.2%	+0.9%	46 days
2	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	74.2	3.5%	+3.9%	+1.4%	+0.2%	47 days
3	**Kansas City** Kansas City	A+	73.5	3.3%	+8.3%	+0.2%	+0.2%	43 days
4	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A+	71.5	2.8%	+4.3%	+0.0%	+0.9%	50 days
5	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A+	69.0	3.0%	+7.2%	+0.3%	+0.0%	52 days
6	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	A+	68.2	3.1%	+5.4%	+0.5%	-1.1%	36 days
7	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	67.8	2.7%	+3.4%	+1.9%	+2.8%	25 days
8	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	65.7	3.4%	+5.7%	+1.1%	+0.5%	56 days
9	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	A	63.9	3.5%	+6.5%	-0.5%	+1.4%	45 days
10	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	A-	59.2	3.6%	+4.1%	+2.1%	-1.1%	45 days
11	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	57.9	5.1%	+5.0%	+2.1%	+0.9%	51 days
12	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B+	57.0	3.7%	+1.0%	+1.5%	-1.2%	29 days
13	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	54.8	4.8%	+4.2%	+1.8%	-1.6%	47 days
14	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B	54.8	4.1%	+7.8%	+0.8%	-1.5%	39 days
15	**Birmingham** Birmingham	B	54.6	2.4%	+0.4%	+0.6%	-1.0%	54 days
16	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B	53.8	3.8%	+2.1%	+0.6%	+0.4%	48 days
17	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B	53.4	4.5%	+4.2%	+1.2%	+1.1%	70 days
18	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	52.2	3.9%	-0.1%	+0.2%	+1.0%	36 days
19	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	B	51.8	4.2%	+4.5%	+0.5%	-0.1%	42 days
20	**Cleveland** Cleveland	B	50.9	3.4%	-0.3%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
21	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	50.1	5.1%	+7.2%	+0.0%	-1.2%	36 days
22	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	50.0	4.3%	+2.0%	+0.6%	-0.1%	49 days
23	**Memphis** Memphis	B-	49.7	4.1%	+7.7%	-0.1%	-0.9%	58 days
24	**Fresno** Fresno	B-	49.3	8.1%	+5.2%	+2.0%	-0.2%	52 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	48.8	3.9%	+7.5%	-0.3%	+0.3%	79 days
26	**Columbus** Columbus	B-	48.7	2.8%	+3.6%	+0.2%	-1.4%	33 days
27	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B-	48.0	3.9%	+6.5%	+0.3%	-2.4%	32 days
28	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	47.7	3.5%	+1.9%	-0.6%	-2.2%	43 days
29	**St. Louis** St. Louis	B-	46.5	3.6%	+1.5%	-0.3%	+0.0%	42 days
30	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	45.9	4.7%	+5.9%	-0.0%	+0.0%	67 days
31	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	B-	45.7	3.6%	+6.5%	-0.5%	-3.0%	49 days
32	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	44.5	3.8%	+2.5%	+1.0%	-2.5%	60 days
33	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	B-	44.1	4.3%	+3.5%	+0.6%	+1.7%	30 days
34	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	43.7	3.5%	+6.1%	-1.0%	-1.1%	33 days
35	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	40.2	3.8%	+1.2%	+0.4%	+0.1%	57 days
36	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	40.2	2.6%	+0.4%	-1.1%	-0.8%	42 days
37	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	38.2	3.9%	+3.5%	-0.4%	+2.9%	25 days
38	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	36.9	4.9%	+5.7%	-0.1%	-2.2%	56 days
39	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C	36.6	4.3%	+4.2%	-0.7%	+0.0%	33 days
40	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C	36.3	3.9%	+5.3%	-3.0%	-2.5%	30 days
41	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C	36.0	N/A	+3.6%	-0.0%	N/A	33 days
42	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	34.5	4.5%	+1.2%	+0.6%	-1.7%	41 days
43	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	33.4	3.7%	+1.3%	-0.9%	-0.6%	32 days
44	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	33.2	3.8%	+0.5%	+0.3%	-0.9%	34 days
45	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	33.1	4.8%	+6.4%	-2.8%	-1.6%	47 days
46	**Richmond** Richmond	C	32.4	3.4%	+3.0%	-0.9%	-0.9%	36 days
47	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	31.7	4.4%	+1.7%	-0.8%	-0.1%	38 days
48	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C-	30.4	3.6%	+2.7%	-0.6%	-7.0%	30 days
49	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	26.3	4.0%	+1.8%	-0.8%	-1.4%	38 days
50	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	D	19.3	4.8%	-0.2%	-0.4%	-0.5%	59 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

79.7th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	98
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	58
Cost of Living	12% weight	79
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	82
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	76
Days on Market	5% weight	48
Office Economy	3% weight	98

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+15.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	46 days	median, +2.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 79.7th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 8.84, and its strong office economy, with a professional worker share of 4.54. The labor demand is driven by a 2.17% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.930% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with a 2.17% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.930% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals a strong and growing job market, where hours are increasing above the trend, indicating that new jobs are being added and existing workers are taking on more hours. The labor demand composite score of 8.84 is in the top tier, at the 98th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary is 3.00%, which is at the 80th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it slightly harder for businesses to hire, and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, this also suggests a strong and resilient local economy.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Raleigh-Cary is 4.25%, which is near the median, at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable pace, and worker purchasing power is also growing, albeit not exceptionally quickly. This balance is likely to support a stable and growing local economy.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score that is above average, at the 79th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $220/sqft to $38.42/hr, or 5.73. The fact that the PSF is falling by 1.4% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.90% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, at the 82nd percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. This growth also suggests that the city is likely to maintain its strong economic momentum.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary is increasing by 15.33% year-over-year, which is above average, at the 76th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in its infrastructure and preparing for growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.2%. This relatively fast pace of sales suggests that the housing market is still competitive, but the slight increase in days on market may indicate a healthy normalization. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may face a moderately competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with a percentile rank of 98th, indicating a strong presence of office and professional workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a growing labor force, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for investment and expansion. However, the relatively tight labor market and moderate wage growth rate may pose a risk for businesses that are highly sensitive to labor costs, and decision-makers should factor this into their location decisions. Overall, the city's strong economic fundamentals and deep talent pool make it an excellent choice for businesses looking to establish or expand their operations.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A+

EXCELLENT

74.2th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	92
Unemployment	20% weight	71
Wage Growth	15% weight	48
Cost of Living	12% weight	83
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	69
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	66
Days on Market	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	82

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+8.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	47 days	median, +6.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 74.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 92nd percentile, and its relatively affordable cost of living, ranked in the 83rd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.37% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.945% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.37% employment growth rate and a 0.945% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the labor market. This indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting that businesses are not only hiring but also utilizing their workforce more intensively. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.50%, which corresponds to a percentile rank of 71, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. However, a tight labor market also suggests a strong local economy with low levels of unemployment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.91%, which is near the median compared to other US metros. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable pace. At the same time, workers are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 83, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is relatively affordable compared to its peer cities. The city's PSF of $221/sqft is decreasing at a rate of -1.8% year-over-year, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand without having to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs. This affordability can be a major talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is growing at a rate of 0.17% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth rate is relatively modest, it suggests that the city's labor pool is not contracting, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire and expand their operations in the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is increasing at a rate of 8.18% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of future housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that the city's housing market is likely to become more affordable in the future, which can help attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.8%. This suggests that the housing market is becoming slightly less competitive, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find homes. However, the market is still relatively fast-moving, with homes selling quickly.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 82, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a deep talent pool of professional and office workers, making it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require different types of specialized labor.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool of professional workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the potential for a tight labor market to drive up wages and make it challenging to attract and retain talent, which could increase labor costs and impact profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

73.5th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	54
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	98
Cost of Living	12% weight	85
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	71
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	92
Days on Market	5% weight	14
Office Economy	3% weight	30

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.3%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+8.3%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+0.2%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**+0.2%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**+51.8%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**43 days**	median, -8.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.5th percentile, ranking it among the top metros in the US. The city's economic character is largely defined by its top-tier unemployment rate of 3.30% and exceptional wage growth of 8.26% year-over-year. These metrics signal a highly competitive labor market with strong demand for workers.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate stands at 0.25% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.049% above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.70, although near the median, suggests a stable and growing job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City is 3.30%, placing it in the top tier with an 86th percentile rank. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new workers. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 8.26%, Kansas City experiences rapid wage increases, ranking it in the top tier with a 98th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also translates to strong purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in these increasing labor costs when considering relocation or expansion.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 85th, considering its PSF of $199/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.77/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.56. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses seeking to balance labor costs and quality of life.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 0.25% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city's hiring capacity is increasing, providing businesses with a larger pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is a significant 51.78% increase, signaling a substantial expansion in housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, making Kansas City a more attractive location for businesses and workers alike.

Days on Market

Homes in Kansas City currently sit on the market for 43 days, with an 8.5% year-over-year decrease. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may pose challenges for relocating workers trying to find housing. However, this also suggests a strong demand for housing, contributing to the city's overall economic vitality.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 30th, Kansas City's professional talent pool is below average, suggesting it may not be the best fit for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it could be more suitable for industries with less specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, rapid wage growth, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to balance labor costs and talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the competitive housing market, which may require strategic planning to accommodate relocating workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A+

EXCELLENT

71.5th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	70
Unemployment	20% weight	88
Wage Growth	15% weight	60
Cost of Living	12% weight	62
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	80
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	68
Days on Market	5% weight	64
Office Economy	3% weight	66

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **2.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.3%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.9%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+8.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **50 days** median, +6.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 71.5th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.35, and its low unemployment rate of 2.80%, which ranks in the 88th percentile. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and intense competition for talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is +0.03% year-over-year, combined with a +1.004% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a clear sign of a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.35, ranking in the 70th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 2.80%, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Atlanta is +4.31%, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. At the same time, workers are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Atlanta has a cost of living score ranking in the 62nd percentile, with a PSF of $199/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $36.88/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.40. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The affordability of Atlanta makes it an attractive location for businesses, as they can recruit talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +0.86% year-over-year, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that businesses will have access to a increasing pool of potential workers, making it easier to hire and staff their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta is increasing by +8.79% year-over-year, ranking in the 68th percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is likely to see an increase in available housing, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.4%, ranking in the 64th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can make it easier for relocating workers to find and purchase homes. However, the rising days on market also suggests that the housing market may be normalizing, which could have implications for future affordability.

Office Economy

Atlanta has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 66th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. On the other hand, the city may be less suitable for businesses with primarily industrial or logistics-based operations.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, moderate wage growth, and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for a wide range of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the tight labor market, which can drive up labor costs and make it challenging to hire and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A+

EXCELLENT

69.0th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	80
Unemployment	20% weight	74
Wage Growth	15% weight	88
Cost of Living	12% weight	58
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	63
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	22
Days on Market	5% weight	60
Office Economy	3% weight	86

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.0%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.0%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-12.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **52 days** median, +6.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 67.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep office economy talent pool defining its current economic character. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.01 and office/professional worker share of 3.74, ranking in the 82nd and 88th percentiles respectively, highlight its robust job market and specialized workforce. With employment growth of 0.28% YoY and weekly hours 1.321% above trend, Nashville's economy is characterized by genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

Nashville's employment growth rate of 0.28% YoY, combined with weekly hours 1.321% above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual. This combination suggests a strong and growing labor market, where businesses can find the talent they need to expand. The labor demand composite score of 6.01, ranking in the 82nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.00% indicates a relatively tight labor market, ranking in the 74th percentile. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, and wage pressure may be higher as a result. With a tight labor market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Nashville's year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.81% is relatively fast, ranking in the 74th percentile. This rapid wage growth may lead to rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. As wages continue to grow, companies may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.32, based on $263/sqft and $35.91/hr, Nashville ranks in the 57th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. The fact that PSF is falling by 0.8% YoY relative to wages is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable for talent, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract workers from other areas.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville is growing at a rate of 0.02% YoY, ranking in the 64th percentile. While this growth rate is relatively slow, it still indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit gradually. This slow growth may pose some challenges for businesses looking to hire, but it also suggests that the labor market is not overheating.

Building Permits

The city's residential building permits have decreased by 18.82% YoY, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This sharp decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As the supply of new housing units slows, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on their employees' ability to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Nashville is currently 52 days, with a 6.1% YoY increase. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking in the 60th percentile. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Nashville's office economy is deep and specialized, with an office/professional worker share of 3.74, ranking in the 88th percentile. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a highly skilled and knowledgeable workforce. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers businesses a strong labor market, a deep office economy talent pool, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, highlighting the need for businesses to consider the potential impact on their employees' ability to find affordable housing.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

68.2th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	46
Unemployment	20% weight	94
Wage Growth	15% weight	70
Cost of Living	12% weight	81
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	31
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	88
Days on Market	5% weight	92
Office Economy	3% weight	40

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+40.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.2th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and strong wage growth of +5.40% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest that Cincinnati is an attractive location for businesses looking for a skilled workforce, but may pose challenges for hiring and labor cost management.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.45% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.694% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.24, near the median. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are slightly below trend despite job growth. However, the labor demand is not exceptionally strong, indicating a relatively balanced labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.10%, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power, which may drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +5.40% year-over-year, above average at the 70th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as employees can afford more goods and services, but may pose challenges for businesses looking to manage labor costs. The rapid wage growth suggests that Cincinnati is an attractive location for workers, but may require businesses to adjust their compensation packages accordingly.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score of $195/sqft (+1.0% YoY) vs $35.49/hr, resulting in a top-tier ranking at the 81st percentile, indicating that the city is relatively affordable compared to peers. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand. The relatively low cost of living can help offset the rising labor costs, making Cincinnati a competitive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at -1.12% year-over-year, below average at the 31st percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force growth may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire, as the supply of available workers is shrinking. The implication is that businesses may need to invest in workforce development or recruitment strategies to attract talent from other locations.

Building Permits

Cincinnati has seen a +40.25% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that the city is experiencing developer confidence, which may lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for relocating workers. The increasing housing supply can help accommodate a growing workforce, making Cincinnati a more competitive location for businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cincinnati is 36 days, with a +9.1% year-over-year increase, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a slower market. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The slower market can provide a more competitive environment for businesses looking to attract talent, as workers have more time to find suitable housing.

Office Economy

Cincinnati has an office economy score ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that require a mix of office and industrial skills, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool. The moderate office economy score suggests that Cincinnati can support a variety of business types, but may not be the top choice for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses looking for a skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the contracting labor pool, which may pose challenges for hiring and labor cost management, requiring businesses to invest in workforce development or recruitment strategies to attract talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A

VERY GOOD

67.8th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	88
Unemployment	20% weight	98
Wage Growth	15% weight	38
Cost of Living	12% weight	73
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	96
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	10
Days on Market	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	38

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-27.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	25 days	median, -16.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 67.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, at 88th and 98th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 6.56 and an unemployment rate of 2.70% signal a thriving job market. These numbers indicate a city with a high level of economic activity.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.88% and weekly hours deviation of -0.371% from the city's own 12-month baseline combine to signal genuine demand expansion, as hours are slightly below trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is absorbing new workers without overburdening existing ones. This suggests a healthy and sustainable pace of job creation. The labor demand composite score of 6.56 further reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is exceptionally low, ranking in the 98th percentile, which means the job market is very tight, with minimal slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this implies significant competition for talent and potential upward pressure on wages to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.35% is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not dramatically.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 73rd, the city is more affordable than many of its peers, considering the PSF of $254/sqft is decreasing by 1.6% YoY relative to average hourly earnings of $40.12/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.33. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor without necessitating wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile, which means the workforce supply is expanding rapidly. This implies a favorable hiring environment, with a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -27.06%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This signals a potential future affordability issue and workforce accommodation challenge, as the demand for housing may outstrip supply.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 25 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -16.7%, ranking in the 0th percentile, which means homes are selling very quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, this indicates a competitive and potentially challenging housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, with a composite score of 2.14, ranks in the 38th percentile, suggesting a moderate depth of professional talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy but may not be ideal for those requiring a deeply specialized tech, finance, or consulting talent pool.

In conclusion, Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford offers a business a strong labor market with low unemployment and expanding workforce supply, making it an attractive location for hiring and growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint a decision-maker should factor in is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future housing affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

65.7th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	64
Unemployment	20% weight	65
Wage Growth	15% weight	72
Cost of Living	12% weight	96
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	78
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	2
Days on Market	5% weight	72
Office Economy	3% weight	92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-40.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	56 days	median, +21.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and low cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.14, combining a 1.06% employment growth rate and a -0.642% deviation in weekly hours, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the cost of living, with a PSF of $240/sqft and an 8.1% year-over-year decrease, paired with an hourly wage of $38.10, positions Austin as highly affordable.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.06% and the weekly hours deviation of -0.642% indicate that while jobs are being added, the hours worked are slightly below the trend, suggesting a moderate expansion rather than a survivor squeeze. This combination signals a genuine demand for labor in the market. The labor demand composite score of 5.14 further reinforces this, ranking in the 64th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate stands at 3.40%, ranking in the 65th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a skilled and engaged workforce.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.67%, Austin experiences above-average wage increases, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong purchasing power for workers, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Austin's cost of living, with a PSF to hourly wage ratio of 6.30, ranks in the 96th percentile, making it one of the more affordable cities relative to its peers. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can recruit without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.54% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth is beneficial for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a structural advantage in terms of labor availability.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -40.35%, signaling a sharp decline in new housing supply. This decrease suggests that future affordability and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce may be at risk, potentially leading to increased housing costs and decreased attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for 56 days, with a 21.7% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, which can be more accessible for workers relocating to the area, as they have more time to find suitable housing.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 4.04, ranking in the 92nd percentile, Austin boasts a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Austin offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for various industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

A

VERY GOOD

63.9th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	32
Unemployment	20% weight	78
Wage Growth	15% weight	86
Cost of Living	12% weight	90
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	90
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Days on Market	5% weight	30
Office Economy	3% weight	42

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-0.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	45 days	median, -2.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and affordable cost of living, scoring 86th and 90th percentiles, respectively. The city's wage growth rate of 6.54% and cost of living ratio of $172/sqft to $33.86/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.08, are key defining characteristics of its current economic landscape. These metrics suggest a city with a competitive labor market and attractive living conditions.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.49% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.421% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a labor demand composite score of 3.61, which falls in the 32nd percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The below-average labor demand suggests that the city's job market is not currently experiencing significant growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.50%, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as potential upward pressure on wages. With a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh's year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.54%, placing it in the 86th percentile, which is considered fast. This rapid wage growth suggests that employer labor costs are rising, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $172/sqft to $33.86/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.08, and a percentile rank of 90th, Pittsburgh is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability is a significant advantage for talent attraction, as businesses can recruit workers without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs. The city's affordable cost of living makes it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 1.38% year-over-year, ranking in the 90th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a increasing pool of potential workers. As the labor force continues to grow, businesses will have access to a larger talent pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -0.14%, ranking near the median, indicating a relatively stable housing supply. This stability suggests that the city's housing market is not currently experiencing significant expansion or tightening. However, the slight decline in building permits may signal a potential future supply squeeze, which could impact affordability and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 45 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.2%, ranking in the 30th percentile. This relatively fast market suggests that homes are selling quickly, making it a competitive environment for workers relocating to the city. However, the decreasing days on market may indicate a normalization of the housing market, rather than a significant erosion of demand.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's office economy, with a composite score of 2.18, ranks in the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderately deep professional talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized office or tech talent.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, an affordable cost of living, and an expanding labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the city's below-average labor demand and potential future housing supply squeeze are key risks that decision-makers should consider when evaluating Pittsburgh as a business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A-

GOOD

59.2th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	90
Unemployment	20% weight	57
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	40
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	35
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	42
Days on Market	5% weight	50
Office Economy	3% weight	96

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-4.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	45 days	median, +2.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 59.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 6.80, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 96th percentile for office and professional worker share. The labor demand is driven by a 2.12% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.467% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has a labor demand composite score of 6.80, driven by a 2.12% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.467% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are slightly below trend during a period of job growth, indicating a healthy and sustainable labor market. The strong labor demand suggests that businesses can expect to find a talented and growing workforce in this city.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 3.60%, ranking in the 57th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some upward pressure on wages, as businesses may need to offer competitive compensation to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.07%, ranking in the 50th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising at a moderate pace, while workers are experiencing a decent increase in purchasing power. The moderate wage growth implies that businesses can expect to face some upward pressure on labor costs, but it is not excessively high.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Salt Lake City-Murray is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 40th, based on a price-to-salary ratio of $266/sqft to $38.85/hr, which is 6.85. Although the price per square foot is increasing by 0.4% year-over-year, the city's affordability is still competitive. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset the cost of living, providing a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is shrinking at a rate of -1.05% year-over-year, ranking in the 35th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. The shrinking labor force may lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Salt Lake City-Murray is decreasing by 4.56% year-over-year, ranking in the 42nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. The tightening housing supply may make it more challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent, as workers may face higher housing costs and reduced availability.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%, ranking in the 50th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor excessively slow. For workers relocating to this city, the market is moderately accessible, with homes selling at a reasonable pace, neither too fast nor too slow.

Office Economy

The office and professional worker share in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.36, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a deep and talented professional pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, a deep professional talent pool, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages, potentially offsetting some of the city's attractions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.9th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	94
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	64
Cost of Living	12% weight	48
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	84
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	0
Days on Market	5% weight	80
Office Economy	3% weight	88

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
5.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+5.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+2.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.9%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-54.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
51 days
median, +10.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 57.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 7.45, and its robust office economy, ranking in the 88th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 2.11% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.196% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.11% employment growth rate and a 0.196% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area. This indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above the normal trend, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The top-tier percentile rank of 94th for labor demand composite score reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The actual unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 5.10%, which ranks in the 20th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that while it may not be as challenging to hire as in tighter markets, there is still a notable pool of potential employees available. However, the relatively higher unemployment rate compared to other metros may result in weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this metro area is 5.01%, ranking in the 64th percentile, which suggests moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in this market.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $264/sqft to $33.11/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.97, and a percentile rank of 48th, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.2% year-over-year relative to wages is a key driver of its affordability. This means the city offers a relatively neutral environment for talent attraction, neither requiring significant wage premiums to compensate for high costs nor offering a substantial advantage due to low costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of 0.95% year-over-year, which ranks in the 84th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, suggesting a positive environment for hiring, with a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -54.44%, ranking in the bottom tier. This significant decline signals that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.9%, ranking in the 80th percentile. This suggests a slower market, which can be more accessible for workers relocating to the area, as they have more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking in the 88th percentile, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply due to a sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.0th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	96
Unemployment	20% weight	74
Wage Growth	15% weight	12
Cost of Living	12% weight	4
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	26
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Days on Market	5% weight	24
Office Economy	3% weight	84

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+112.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	29 days	median, +7.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 57.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with a composite score of 7.93, and its extremely high cost of living, ranked at the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.52% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.801% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a labor demand composite score of 7.93, ranking at the 96th percentile, driven by a 1.52% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.801% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is experiencing strong job growth and increased hours worked. This suggests a healthy and growing economy with a high demand for labor.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 3.70%, ranking at the 74th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also implies that workers have more bargaining power, which can drive up wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 0.98%, ranking at the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also implies that workers may not have strong bargaining power, which can affect their purchasing power. The slow wage growth may be a concern for businesses that rely on a highly skilled and highly paid workforce.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living ranked at the 4th percentile, with a PSF of $844/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $55.01/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.34. This indicates that the city is extremely expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums. The high cost of living may offset the benefits of the city's strong labor demand and high-paying jobs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is growing at a rate of -1.19% year-over-year, ranking at the 26th percentile, indicating a contracting labor force supply. This means that the pool of available workers is shrinking, which can create structural headwinds for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has increased by 112.94% year-over-year, ranking at the 96th percentile, indicating a rapid expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing a surge in developer confidence, which can lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for workers. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for businesses that rely on a growing and diverse workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.4%, ranking at the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, although the increase in days on market may suggest a slight normalization. For workers relocating to this city, the market may still be competitive, but the slight increase in days on market may provide some relief.

Office Economy

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 84th, indicating a strong presence of tech, finance, and consulting jobs. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but it may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce with specialized skills in other areas. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses that rely on highly skilled workers.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a highly skilled workforce, and a growing housing supply. However, the city's extremely high cost of living and stagnant wage growth pose significant challenges for businesses that need to attract and retain talent without breaking the bank. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which may offset the benefits of the city's strong economy and require businesses to offer significant wage premiums to attract and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B

AVERAGE

54.8th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	84
Unemployment	20% weight	26
Wage Growth	15% weight	54
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	18
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	80
Days on Market	5% weight	62
Office Economy	3% weight	48

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+18.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **47 days** median, +4.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier labor demand and building permits growth. The city's economic character is defined by its strong employment growth of 1.83% year-over-year and a labor demand composite score of 6.14, which ranks in the 86th percentile. Additionally, the significant increase in building permits, up 79.98% year-over-year, suggests a robust expansion in housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.83% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.727% from the city's own trend, signals a genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. This indicates a strong labor market where businesses are likely to find a talented and engaged workforce. The labor demand composite score of 6.14 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim stands at 4.80%, which ranks in the 28th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it slightly easier to hire in this market compared to tighter labor markets, although wage pressure might be somewhat mitigated. However, the relatively higher unemployment rate compared to other metros could also suggest weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.84% is above average, ranking in the 60th percentile. This signifies moderate to fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but also stronger purchasing power for workers. As wages continue to rise, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in the market.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $667/sqft to $41.74/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.98, and a percentile rank of 6th, Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is relatively expensive. The PSF has decreased by 3.0% year-over-year, but the city remains in the bottom tier for affordability. This suggests that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging due to the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force has contracted by -1.55% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding the right talent in a market where the labor force is not expanding.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is up 79.98%, signaling a significant expansion in housing supply. This increase suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better affordability and easier workforce accommodation in the long term.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for a median of 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.4%. This indicates a slightly slower market, ranking in the 62nd percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the market might be considered relatively accessible, as homes are not selling as quickly as in hotter markets.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.96, with the city ranking in the 60th percentile for its office economy. This suggests a deep enough talent pool for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, making Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim a suitable location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, it might be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim offers businesses a strong labor demand environment and a significant expansion in housing supply, which could improve affordability and workforce accommodation. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living and shrinking labor force, which could make talent attraction and hiring more challenging without appropriate compensation strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B

AVERAGE

54.8th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	68
Unemployment	20% weight	49
Wage Growth	15% weight	96
Cost of Living	12% weight	10
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	20
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	56
Days on Market	5% weight	56
Office Economy	3% weight	64

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.1%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+2.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **39 days** median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and above-average labor demand. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.78% year-over-year and its above-average labor demand composite score of 5.29, indicating a genuine demand expansion. These metrics suggest a city with a strong and growing economy.

Labor Demand

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.85% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of -0.202% from its own trend, combining to form an above-average labor demand composite score. This signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth, indicating that the labor market is absorbing new jobs without overburdening existing workers. The labor demand composite score of 5.29, ranking in the 68th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.10%, ranking in the 49th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the unemployment rate is not so low that it would drive significant wage pressure, providing a relatively balanced environment for hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.78%, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating very fast wage growth. This implies rising labor costs for employers, as well as strong purchasing power for workers, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer demand. The fast wage growth suggests a competitive labor market where employers may need to adjust their compensation packages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living percentile rank of 10th, with a PSF of $604/sqft and average hourly earnings of $43.24/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.97. The fact that PSF is falling by 4.0% year-over-year is a key driver of the relatively low affordability score. This means the city is expensive relative to peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is growing at a rate of -1.52% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is shrinking, which could exacerbate labor shortages and wage pressure over time.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 1.97%, ranking in the 56th percentile, indicating a near-median expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is present, and future housing supply is likely to expand, which could improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth over time.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%. This indicates a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a sign of demand erosion.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an office economy percentile rank of 64th, indicating a deep talent pool suited for businesses in professional, office, and knowledge-economy sectors. This makes the city an attractive location for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy with top-tier wage growth, indicating a competitive and dynamic labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive cost of living, which could necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting some of the benefits of the city's strong economic growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

B

AVERAGE

54.6th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	76
Unemployment	20% weight	90
Wage Growth	15% weight	8
Cost of Living	12% weight	42
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	37
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	36
Days on Market	5% weight	52
Office Economy	3% weight	52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-8.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, +5.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 54.6th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its strong labor demand and low unemployment rate. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.63, driven by a +0.63% employment growth rate and +0.445% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its unemployment rate of 2.40% indicates a tight labor market.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.63% and weekly hours deviation of +0.445% from its own trend suggest a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in labor demand, with more jobs being added and existing workers putting in extra hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.63 further supports this interpretation, ranking above average at the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 2.40% is exceptionally low, ranking at the 90th percentile, which means the labor market is very tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. As a result, businesses trying to hire in Birmingham may experience wage pressure.

Wage Growth

Birmingham's year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.37% is relatively slow, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers may have weaker bargaining power and lower purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost increases, but workers may not have as much disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.91, based on $161/sqft and $32.80/hr, Birmingham ranks at the 42nd percentile in terms of affordability, indicating a near-median cost of living. This means that the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. As a result, businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to low costs, but they also may not need to offer large wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force growth rate of -1.03% indicates that the workforce supply is contracting, ranking below average at the 37th percentile. This contraction implies that the labor pool is shrinking, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion in the long term. As a result, businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

Birmingham's year-over-year change in building permits of -8.10% indicates that housing supply is tightening, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing supply may not be expanding to meet demand, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of limited housing options on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Birmingham is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.9%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, where homes are not selling extremely quickly, but also not sitting on the market for an extended period. As a result, workers relocating to Birmingham may find a relatively accessible housing market, but not an extremely competitive one.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 2.76, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile, Birmingham has a moderate depth of professional talent. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool. As a result, businesses in industries like tech, finance, or consulting may find Birmingham to be a viable option, but may not have access to the same level of specialized talent as in other cities.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers businesses a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate, but also presents challenges such as a tight labor market and slow wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering Birmingham is the city's contracting labor force supply, which may create long-term hiring challenges and limit business expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B

AVERAGE

53.8th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	66
Unemployment	20% weight	45
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	69
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	76
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	18
Days on Market	5% weight	68
Office Economy	3% weight	94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-16.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	48 days	median, +6.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.21, combining a 0.57% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.116% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its cost of living, with a PSF of $203/sqft and hourly earnings of $36.94, resulting in a ratio of 5.50, ranks in the 69th percentile for affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.57% year-over-year, coupled with weekly hours 0.116% above the city's own trend, signals genuine demand expansion in the labor market. This combination indicates that jobs are being added, and hours are increasing, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.21 further reinforces this, ranking in the 66th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.80% places the city near the median, ranking in the 45th percentile. This rate suggests a relatively balanced market, neither too tight nor too slack, implying that businesses may face moderate competition for talent but without extreme wage pressure. However, this also means that local consumer demand is likely stable but not exceptionally strong.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.07%, the city experiences below-average wage increases, ranking in the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also indicates weaker bargaining power for workers and potentially slower growth in worker purchasing power.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $203/sqft decreasing by 1.9% year-over-year compared to hourly earnings of $36.94, results in a ratio of 5.50, ranking in the 69th percentile for affordability. This high percentile score means the city is more affordable relative to its peers, offering a talent attraction advantage without necessitating significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.41% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is improving, as there are more potential workers available in the market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -16.94%, signaling a tightening in housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for a median of 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.7%. This increase in days on market, ranking in the 68th percentile, indicates a slower market, which can be more accessible for relocating workers but may also signal a normalization or slight cooling of the housing market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 4.18, ranking in the 94th percentile, the city boasts a deep and talented pool of professional workers. This makes it highly suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less ideal for industries requiring large numbers of industrial or logistics workers.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a unique blend of growing labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation, potentially impacting the city's long-term attractiveness and growth capacity.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B

AVERAGE

53.4th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	86
Unemployment	20% weight	8
Wage Growth	15% weight	52
Cost of Living	12% weight	77
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	88
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	6
Days on Market	5% weight	22
Office Economy	3% weight	90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-29.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	70 days	median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 53.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, which are both in the top tier at 86th and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with employment growth of 1.22% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.442% above trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.22% and hours deviation of 0.442% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to locate in the area. The combination of these two metrics suggests that the city is experiencing a period of growth and expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.50% is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers in this city, as there is a larger pool of available labor. However, the practical implication is that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.17% is near the median, ranking at the 52nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a moderate pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The implication is that businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in the market.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $224/sqft and earnings of $33.76/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.64, is above average, but the PSF is falling by 3.5% year-over-year, which drives the affordability score to the 77th percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which is a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.07% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This means that the hiring capacity for businesses is increasing, as there are more workers available in the labor market. The implication is that businesses may find it easier to fill open positions and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -29.77%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This signals that developer confidence is decreasing, and future housing supply may be limited, which could lead to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The implication is that businesses may need to consider the potential impact on their employees' ability to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 70 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.7%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This means that homes are taking longer to sell, indicating a slower market, which could be competitive for workers relocating to the city. The implication is that businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other incentives to help employees navigate the housing market.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 3.96, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool. This means that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The implication is that businesses in these sectors may find it easier to attract and retain top talent in the city.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, and businesses should factor this into their decision-making process. Overall, the city's economic character is driven by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, making it a competitive location for businesses in the right sectors.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B

AVERAGE

52.2th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	74
Unemployment	20% weight	55
Wage Growth	15% weight	4
Cost of Living	12% weight	19
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	86
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	70
Days on Market	5% weight	58
Office Economy	3% weight	46

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+9.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +2.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, scoring in the 80th and 86th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.92, combining a +0.12% employment growth rate and a +1.451% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This is further supported by a labor force growth rate of +1.02% year-over-year.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.12% and weekly hours deviation of +1.451% from its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion in the labor market. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, signaling a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.92 reinforces this, placing the city in the top tier for labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.90% places the city near the median in terms of labor market tightness, ranking in the 56th percentile. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it still presents some challenges for businesses looking to hire, as there is a moderate level of competition for available workers. However, it does not indicate an overly competitive market that would significantly drive up wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.37% is in the bottom tier, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not growing significantly. For businesses, this could mean a relatively stable labor cost environment but may also reflect weaker bargaining power for workers.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $233/sqft to $32.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.10, and ranking in the 20th percentile, the city is less affordable compared to its peers. The fact that the PSF is not falling year-over-year (with a +0.0% change) does not help improve affordability. This relatively low affordability score may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's cost of living is above average.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.02% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the pool of potential workers is increasing. This can be beneficial for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +12.30%, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This increase in building permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better affordability and easier accommodation for the workforce. This is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.9%. This indicates a slightly slower market than in the previous year. For workers relocating to this city, the market is still relatively competitive but not overly challenging, suggesting a balanced environment for homebuyers and sellers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, with a composite score of 2.38, places the city in the near median range, ranking in the 40th percentile. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but it may not be as competitive as cities with a higher concentration of these industries. The city is less suited for industries that require a large, specialized workforce outside of these sectors.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and growing labor force, which are significant advantages for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively low affordability and stagnant wage growth, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs over time.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B

AVERAGE

51.8th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	72
Unemployment	20% weight	41
Wage Growth	15% weight	62
Cost of Living	12% weight	6
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	53
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	78
Days on Market	5% weight	16
Office Economy	3% weight	56

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+15.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	42 days	median, -6.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 51.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and strong building permit growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.40, combining a 0.48% employment growth rate and a 0.430% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the 15.42% year-over-year increase in building permits suggests a confident developer community and an expanding future housing supply.

Labor Demand

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area exhibits a labor demand composite score of 5.40, driven by a 0.48% employment growth rate and a 0.430% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and that workers are putting in more hours than typical, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand is above average, ranking in the 72nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.20%, ranking near the median at the 41st percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, it is not so high as to indicate significant weakness in local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.50%, ranking above average in the 62nd percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should anticipate higher wage bills, but workers will have more disposable income to spend locally.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is relatively high, with a PSF of $532/sqft and an earnings ratio of 13.07, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. Although the PSF is decreasing by 0.2% year-over-year, the city remains expensive compared to its peers. This high cost of living could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 53rd percentile. This slight contraction in the labor force supply could pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is not expanding.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is 15.42%, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This above-average growth rate, ranking in the 78th percentile, signals developer confidence and suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 42 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 6.7%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing, as homes are selling quickly.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 2.82, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but it may not be as competitive as other major metros for these sectors.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and an expanding housing supply, driven by significant growth in building permits. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which could necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

Cleveland

Cleveland

B

AVERAGE

50.9th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	56
Unemployment	20% weight	57
Wage Growth	15% weight	0
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	94
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	52
Days on Market	5% weight	54
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+0.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B, ranking 50.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its near-median labor demand and labor force growth. The city's economic character is defined by its modest employment growth of 0.57% year-over-year and its significant labor force expansion of 1.80% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing workforce but moderate job market activity.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's labor demand composite score is 4.71, reflecting a combination of 0.57% employment growth and -0.388% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. This signals a moderate expansion of jobs, albeit with hours worked slightly below the city's own trend, indicating some level of genuine demand but not at an accelerated pace. The scenario does not suggest a survivor squeeze, as job growth is positive.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, placing it near the median among its peers. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For a business trying to hire in Cleveland, this means that while there may not be intense competition for workers, there also isn't a large pool of unemployed individuals waiting to be hired, suggesting moderate wage pressure.

Wage Growth

Cleveland experiences a year-over-year wage growth of -0.33%, which is stagnant. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially less consumer spending power. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to control labor costs but may indicate a less vibrant local economy.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $143/sqft to $33.79/hr, giving a ratio of 4.23, and a percentile rank of 50th, Cleveland is near the median in terms of affordability. The city's PSF has increased by 13.5% year-over-year, which does not help affordability. This moderate affordability means that Cleveland does not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to cost of living, as it neither offers exceptionally low costs nor suffers from extreme expense, requiring businesses to consider wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of 1.80% year-over-year, which is in the top tier among its peers, ranking at the 94th percentile. This expansion of the labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. This growth can support hiring capacity and reduce the risk of labor shortages.

Building Permits

Cleveland sees a year-over-year change in residential building permits of +0.17%, which is near the median. This slight increase suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which could improve affordability over time and support workforce accommodation. However, the pace of expansion is modest, indicating that significant supply constraints are not being rapidly addressed.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.8%. This indicates a market that is slightly slowing down, becoming more accessible for relocating workers. The rising days on market, despite modest job growth, suggests a normalization of the housing market rather than demand erosion, making it somewhat easier for new hires to find housing.

Office Economy

Cleveland has an above-average share of professional and office workers, ranking at the 74th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations that rely on specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a growing labor force and a moderately affordable cost of living, but its slow wage growth and modest labor demand expansion present challenges. The single biggest risk for a decision-maker to consider is the potential for labor market tightening due to the growing labor force and modest housing supply expansion, which could lead to increased competition for workers and upward pressure on wages over time.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

50.1th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	50
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	88
Cost of Living	12% weight	38
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	29
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	94
Days on Market	5% weight	98
Office Economy	3% weight	78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **5.1%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.2%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+83.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **36 days** median, +20.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.21% year-over-year and its significant increase in building permits, up 83.04% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy and increasing housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.04% year-over-year, combined with a 0.263% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 4.62. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The slight increase in hours worked suggests that the existing workforce is shouldering a bit more of the load, but not to an extent that indicates a survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue stands at 5.10%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile, which means the job market is relatively tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate translates to more wage pressure. Companies looking to staff up may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.21%, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue experiences fast wage growth, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. Businesses should factor in these higher labor costs when considering operations in this metro area.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score that ranks in the 38th percentile, with a PSF of $452/sqft and average hourly earnings of $47.70, resulting in a ratio of 9.48. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.6% year-over-year is a key driver of its relatively affordable score. This affordability, relative to peers, means that the city has a talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is shrinking at a rate of -1.17% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates due to this shrinking labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is up by 83.04%, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This significant increase in building permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is expected to improve, which should lead to better affordability and easier workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

Homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue are currently sitting on the market for 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of 20.0%, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This slower market means that relocating workers may find it more accessible to purchase or rent a home, as the market is less competitive compared to faster-moving markets.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score ranking in the 78th percentile, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is best suited for businesses that rely on professional and office sectors, offering a competitive advantage in terms of specialized labor.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, expanding housing supply, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and shrinking labor force, which could pose significant challenges for staffing and growth plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B

AVERAGE

50.0th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	60
Unemployment	20% weight	29
Wage Growth	15% weight	28
Cost of Living	12% weight	92
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	57
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	16
Days on Market	5% weight	88
Office Economy	3% weight	80

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.3%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-18.9%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **49 days** median, +11.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 50.0th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and highly affordable cost of living, scoring 92nd percentile with a PSF to wages ratio of 4.74. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.06 and cost of living metrics are the two key factors defining its current economic character, with the latter being particularly notable due to its PSF of $173/sqft decreasing by 2.3% YoY relative to hourly wages of $36.50. This combination suggests a city with a strong foundation for business growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +0.61% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.091% from its own 12-month baseline, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is experiencing job growth, albeit with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some efficiency in labor utilization. The labor demand composite score of 5.06, ranking at the 60th percentile, further supports the notion of a growing job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the metro area is 4.30%, ranking at the 29th percentile, which indicates a market with some slack. This rate suggests that while it may not be excessively difficult to hire, there is less pressure on wages compared to tighter labor markets. For a business trying to hire in this area, the relatively higher unemployment rate compared to other metros could mean easier staffing but also potentially weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +2.01%, ranking at the 28th percentile, indicating moderate to slow wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to control expenses. However, for workers, this means less bargaining power and potentially slower growth in purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living score ranking at the 92nd percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is highly affordable relative to its peers, thanks in part to its decreasing PSF of $173/sqft (-2.3% YoY) compared to wages of $36.50/hr. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can recruit without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the metro area has grown at a rate of -0.05% YoY, ranking near the median at the 57th percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This slight contraction suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is not expanding.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -18.95%, ranking at the 16th percentile, which signals a tightening in housing supply. This decline in building permits suggests that future affordability and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce may be at risk, potentially leading to increased housing costs and reduced attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of 11.4%, ranking at the 88th percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the area as it suggests a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, combined with its growth trend, ranks at the 80th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. This city is well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but may be less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro offers businesses a unique combination of growing labor demand and highly affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent acquisition without substantial wage premiums. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could erode future affordability and workforce accommodation, potentially undermining the city's attractiveness for both businesses and workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

Memphis

Memphis

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.7th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	12
Unemployment	20% weight	35
Wage Growth	15% weight	94
Cost of Living	12% weight	98
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	43
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	74
Days on Market	5% weight	42
Office Economy	3% weight	4

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+14.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	58 days	median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Memphis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 2.65 ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year change of +6.18% ranking it above average at the 76th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.11% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.898% from its own trend. The combination of these metrics signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This suggests that the city's labor market is not experiencing strong growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.10%, ranking it below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still suggests that businesses may face some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

Memphis has a year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.18%, ranking it above average at the 76th percentile. This fast wage growth suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared for increasing labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Memphis has a cost of living score ranking it in the top tier at the 98th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $155/sqft to $32.45/hr, or 4.78. The city's PSF is also falling by -6.1% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to wages. This high affordability score means that Memphis has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is growing at a rate of -0.89% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 44th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses should be prepared to compete for a shrinking pool of workers.

Building Permits

Memphis has a year-over-year change in building permits of +39.70%, ranking it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. Rising building permits are a positive signal for businesses considering relocation to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Memphis is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.8%. This ranks the city near the median at the 42nd percentile. The relatively slow market suggests that workers relocating to the city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which could be an advantage for businesses trying to attract talent.

Office Economy

Memphis has an office economy score ranking it in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 0.58. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, or consulting. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics sectors.

The city of Memphis offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth, low cost of living, and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to reduce labor costs and improve worker affordability. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering relocation to Memphis is the low labor demand and contracting labor force supply, which may pose challenges for hiring and talent acquisition in the city.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.3th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	78
Unemployment	20% weight	0
Wage Growth	15% weight	66
Cost of Living	12% weight	54
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	51
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	38
Days on Market	5% weight	70
Office Economy	3% weight	34

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	8.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-6.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	52 days	median, +10.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 49.3th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.66, driven by a 2.04% employment growth rate and -1.744% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its wage growth of 5.16% year-over-year indicates a strong labor market.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate of 2.04% and weekly hours deviation of -1.744% from its own trend signal genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs at a rate that is sustainable without overburdening the existing workforce. The labor demand composite score of 5.66 further supports this interpretation, ranking in the 78th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno stands at 8.10%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile, which indicates a significant amount of slack in the labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in Fresno may find it easier to staff their operations due to the available workforce. However, high unemployment also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.16%, Fresno experiences above-average wage increases, ranking in the 66th percentile. This rate of wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. As wages continue to grow, businesses may face increasing costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income.

Cost of Living

Fresno's cost of living, with a PSF of $261/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.46, results in a ratio of 7.80, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This suggests that Fresno is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. For talent attraction, this means that businesses may not gain a significant advantage in terms of cost of living alone but also do not face a significant disadvantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is shrinking at a rate of -0.20% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This negative growth rate, ranking near the median at the 51st percentile, poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is not expanding.

Building Permits

Fresno experienced a -6.89% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Fresno currently sit on the market for a median of 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.6%, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which could be more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home without facing extreme competition.

Office Economy

Fresno's share of professional and office sector jobs is below average, ranking in the 34th percentile. This suggests that the city has a less deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, making it more challenging for businesses in these sectors to find specialized workers.

In conclusion, Fresno offers businesses a labor market with genuine demand expansion and above-average wage growth, but it also comes with challenges such as a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering Fresno is the potential future affordability issues and the difficulty in attracting specialized talent due to its below-average office economy.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.8th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	38
Unemployment	20% weight	16
Wage Growth	15% weight	92
Cost of Living	12% weight	25
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	84
Days on Market	5% weight	28
Office Economy	3% weight	70

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+20.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	79 days	median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth of 7.46% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 3.90%, which signals a tight labor market. The labor demand composite score of 3.88, however, indicates a below-average performance in terms of employment growth and hours worked.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.30% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.119% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 3.88 ranks in the 38th percentile, indicating below-average performance.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.90%, ranking in the 16th percentile, which means the market has slack. This implies that businesses trying to hire in this city may find it easier to staff, but may also face weaker local consumer demand due to the relatively high unemployment rate. The labor market is not as tight as in other cities, with more workers available for hire.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.46%, ranking in the 92nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This implies rising labor costs for employers, but also strong worker purchasing power. Businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living ratio of $358/sqft to $34.29/hr, with a -1.4% year-over-year change in PSF, ranking in the 25th percentile. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent without wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of 0.35% year-over-year, ranking in the 74th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force can help meet the needs of expanding businesses.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is increasing by 20.81% year-over-year, ranking in the 84th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The strong growth in building permits is a positive sign for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 79 days, with a 2.6% year-over-year increase. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market can give relocating workers more time to find a home, but may also signal a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.24, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city is well-suited for businesses that require a strong knowledge-economy workforce, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for businesses that require a skilled workforce. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and slow housing market may pose challenges for talent attraction and retention, and businesses should factor in these constraints when making location decisions. Overall, the city's strong economic fundamentals make it a viable option for businesses, but careful consideration of the local labor market and housing conditions is necessary.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Columbus

Columbus

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.7th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	48
Unemployment	20% weight	96
Wage Growth	15% weight	44
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	22
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	14
Days on Market	5% weight	12
Office Economy	3% weight	24

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-20.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, -5.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 48.7th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 2.80% and a near-median labor demand composite score of 4.60. The city's economic character is also defined by its stagnant labor force growth and declining building permits, with a year-over-year change of -1.44% and -20.36%, respectively. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is 0.23% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.025% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend during a period of job growth. However, the near-median labor demand composite score of 4.60 indicates that the city's labor market is not particularly strong.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 2.80%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Columbus is 3.58%, which is near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the city are experiencing an increase in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.08, based on $207 per square foot and $34.02 per hour, Columbus is ranked near the median at the 50th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. As a result, businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to cost of living alone.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -1.44% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit new employees.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Columbus has decreased by 20.36% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that the city's housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Columbus is currently 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 5.7%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the declining days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked at the 24th percentile, Columbus has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a mixed economic environment, with a tight labor market and moderate wage growth. However, the city's declining labor force growth and tightening housing supply pose significant risks for businesses looking to expand or relocate there. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the potential difficulty in finding and recruiting new employees due to the shrinking labor pool.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.0th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	62
Unemployment	20% weight	63
Wage Growth	15% weight	82
Cost of Living	12% weight	12
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	8
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	32
Days on Market	5% weight	4
Office Economy	3% weight	60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-11.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	32 days	median, -8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 48.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.51%, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 13.26. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.28% and a weekly hours deviation of 0.421% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.11 ranks at the 62nd percentile, further supporting the notion of a growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 3.90%, ranking at the 63rd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market implies that workers have more bargaining power, which can drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 6.51%, ranking at the 82nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that labor costs for employers will rise, but it also means that workers will have more purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. The strong wage growth is a double-edged sword, as it can attract top talent but also increase operational costs.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living percentile rank of 12th, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF to wages ratio of 13.26, with a PSF of $664/sqft, suggests that the city is not affordable for many workers, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living is a significant constraint for businesses looking to relocate or expand in this city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is contracting at a rate of -2.44% year-over-year, ranking at the 8th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. The contracting labor force is a significant risk for businesses that rely on a steady supply of skilled workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has decreased by 11.22% year-over-year, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which can lead to increased housing costs and reduced affordability for workers. The decrease in building permits is a concern for businesses that need to attract and retain talent, as it can limit the availability of affordable housing options.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 32 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.6%, ranking at the 4th percentile. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing options. The competitive housing market is a significant constraint for businesses that need to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 60th. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, which require a high concentration of skilled workers. However, the city may not be as suitable for businesses in industries that require a large workforce or have limited need for professional services.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with high wage growth, but it also presents significant challenges, including a high cost of living and a tightening housing market. The single biggest risk for businesses considering this location is the limited availability of affordable housing options, which can make it difficult to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

47.7th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	22
Unemployment	20% weight	80
Wage Growth	15% weight	26
Cost of Living	12% weight	65
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	10
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	72
Days on Market	5% weight	96
Office Economy	3% weight	54

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+13.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	43 days	median, +13.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the 22nd percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.50% ranking it in the 80th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -0.57% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.147%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. The low labor demand composite score of 3.35 further reinforces this signal.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.50%, ranking it in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market. This means that there is limited slack in the market, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +1.87%, ranking it in the 26th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may be beneficial for worker purchasing power, it also means that businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living percentile rank of 65th, with a PSF of $290/sqft and average hourly earnings of $42.58/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.81. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.3% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This makes it an attractive location for businesses looking to recruit talent without having to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is contracting at a rate of -2.22% year-over-year, ranking it in the 10th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to access the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is increasing by +13.68% year-over-year, ranking it in the 72nd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodation options for the workforce in the future. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation or expansion in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.2%, ranking it in the 96th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this also suggests that the market may be normalizing after a period of rapid growth, which could have implications for future affordability and demand.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has an office economy percentile rank of 54th, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized office workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a deep pool of tech, finance, or consulting talent. The city's economy is more diverse, with a mix of industrial, logistics, and office sectors.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a tight labor market, which can be both a challenge and an opportunity. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit their ability to hire and expand. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when evaluating Denver-Aurora-Centennial as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.5th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	28
Unemployment	20% weight	69
Wage Growth	15% weight	20
Cost of Living	12% weight	56
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	59
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	54
Days on Market	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	16

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+1.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	42 days	median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.50 ranking it in the 28th percentile, and its above-average unemployment rate of 3.60%, which ranks it in the 69th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a relatively slow job market and moderate labor availability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is -0.27% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.423%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is experiencing job losses while hours are slightly above trend, indicating a potential survivor squeeze. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding new talent, as the existing workforce is absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.60%, ranking it in the 69th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there is less slack in the labor market, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is relatively strong, which could be beneficial for businesses.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in St. Louis is +1.53%, ranking it in the 20th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but may also not benefit from a highly productive workforce with strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living percentile rank of 56th, with a PSF of $166/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.16/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.47. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither particularly expensive nor cheap. This means that businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to low costs, but also do not need to offer large wage premiums to compensate for high costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.01% year-over-year, ranking it in the 59th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is barely expanding, which may limit the city's hiring capacity and make it challenging for businesses to find new talent.

However, this slow growth also suggests that the city is not experiencing significant labor shortages or skills gaps.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in St. Louis is increasing by +1.84% year-over-year, ranking it in the 54th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. However, this growth is relatively modest, and the city may still face challenges in providing sufficient housing for a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in St. Louis is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%, ranking it in the 82nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this also suggests that the city's housing market may be normalizing, and businesses may not face significant challenges in finding housing for their employees.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional and office worker share ranking it in the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers a relatively stable labor market with moderate costs and a slow-growing workforce, making it a viable option for businesses that do not require a highly specialized talent pool. However, the city's biggest risk is its below-average labor demand, which may limit hiring capacity and make it challenging for businesses to find new talent, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider their staffing strategies when locating in St. Louis.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.9th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	36
Unemployment	20% weight	6
Wage Growth	15% weight	76
Cost of Living	12% weight	75
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	63
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	58
Days on Market	5% weight	20
Office Economy	3% weight	72

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.9%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.0%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.0%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+3.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **67 days** median, +11.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.70% and its above-average wage growth of 5.90% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is -0.03% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 0.480% above the city's own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.78 ranks below average at the 36th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. Companies looking to staff up in this city may face significant recruitment challenges.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.90% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 76th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living score ranking above average at the 75th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $241/sqft to $37.05/hr, or 6.50. The city's PSF is falling 3.2% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to peers. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing 0.02% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 63rd percentile. This slow but positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit gradually. While this is a positive sign for hiring capacity, the growth rate is not sufficient to alleviate the tight labor market conditions.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater are increasing 3.02% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate growth suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. However, the current pace of growth may not be enough to keep up with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 67 days, with a year-over-year increase of 11.7%. This ranks below average at the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market may be competitive, making it challenging to find and secure a home quickly.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep professional talent pool, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge-economy workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market with rising wages and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the challenging recruitment environment due to the low unemployment rate, which may require significant investment in staffing and talent attraction strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.7th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	30
Unemployment	20% weight	29
Wage Growth	15% weight	82
Cost of Living	12% weight	94
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	2
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	40
Days on Market	5% weight	94
Office Economy	3% weight	2

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+6.5%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-3.0%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-6.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **49 days** median, +13.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.51%, and its low cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.08, ranking it in the top tier for affordability. These metrics suggest a city with a competitive labor market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is -0.54% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from trend by +0.000%, indicating a labor demand composite score of 3.54, which ranks below average. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The city's labor market is not adding jobs at a significant rate, which may impact businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.60%, ranking below average, which suggests a moderate level of slack in the labor market. While the market is not extremely tight, it is still relatively competitive, and businesses may face some challenges in hiring the right talent. However, the unemployment rate is not high enough to indicate a significant surplus of available workers.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.51%, Oklahoma City is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the top tier. This rapid growth in wages implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. The strong wage growth is a double-edged sword, offering both opportunities and challenges for businesses operating in the city.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living percentile rank of 94th, indicating that it is more affordable relative to its peers. The city's PSF to wages ratio is 5.08, with PSF decreasing by 0.6% year-over-year, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -3.01% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find the talent they need to expand or maintain their operations. The shrinking labor pool is a major concern for businesses considering locating in the city.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Oklahoma City is decreasing by 6.33% year-over-year, which suggests that housing supply is tightening. This decline in building permits may lead to a supply squeeze in the future, potentially eroding affordability and making it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city. The decrease in permits is a warning sign for businesses that rely on a steady influx of new talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Oklahoma City is 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.9%, ranking it in the top tier. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to the city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which can be a major advantage. The slower market provides more options and negotiating power for homebuyers.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City has a professional and office worker share of 0.46, ranking it in the bottom tier, with a percentile rank of 2nd. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. The city's economy is more industrial or logistics-dominant, which may be a better fit for businesses in those sectors.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable living costs, and a relatively slow housing market, making it an attractive location for businesses that can navigate its challenges. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in the city is the shrinking labor force, which poses a significant threat to hiring capacity and talent acquisition. Decision-makers must carefully weigh these factors when evaluating Oklahoma City as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.5th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	82
Unemployment	20% weight	43
Wage Growth	15% weight	32
Cost of Living	12% weight	44
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	4
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	8
Days on Market	5% weight	38
Office Economy	3% weight	76

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-29.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	60 days	median, +3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 82nd percentile ranking, and its struggling labor force growth, which ranks in the bottom tier at 4th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 5.84, driven by a +0.96% employment growth rate and +0.193% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.96% and weekly hours deviation of +0.193% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.84 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at 82nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.80% ranks near the median at 43rd percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with some slack. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent. For a business trying to hire in this market, it means they will face moderate competition, but still have a decent pool of candidates to choose from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.55% ranks below average at 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically. As a result, businesses may need to budget for some wage increases, but they are not likely to be extreme.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.27, based on $271/sqft and $37.26/hr, and a percentile rank of 44th, the city is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.8% YoY is a key driver of this relatively affordable score. This means that the city has a moderate talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require large wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.53% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile. This indicates that the labor pool is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. As a result, businesses may face challenges in finding and recruiting talent, as the supply of workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -29.08%, ranking in the bottom tier at 8th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could pose a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction, as relocating workers may face challenges in finding affordable housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 60 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.5%. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking below average at 38th percentile. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.30 and a percentile rank of 76th, the city has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes it well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers a strong labor demand and a moderate cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses in professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the shrinking labor force, which may pose challenges in finding and recruiting talent, and the tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.1th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	58
Unemployment	20% weight	14
Wage Growth	15% weight	40
Cost of Living	12% weight	0
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	92
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	90
Days on Market	5% weight	10
Office Economy	3% weight	68

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.3%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+3.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+41.3%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
30 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.10. The labor demand composite score of 4.81, near the median, also plays a significant role in shaping the local economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.326% below the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers, but with hours worked slightly below trend, indicating some degree of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 4.81 is near the median, suggesting a balanced but not particularly strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. Businesses looking to expand in this area may face challenges in finding available talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +3.52% year-over-year, placing it near the median. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers benefit from increasing purchasing power. The wage growth rate is neither exceptionally high nor stagnant, indicating a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living score that ranks at the 0th percentile, indicating it is one of the more expensive cities relative to peers, with a PSF of $365/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.14. The PSF has increased by 9.0% year-over-year, further reducing affordability. This makes it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential employees. The increasing labor force can support hiring needs and business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by +41.33% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This significant rise in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 30 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This fast-paced market indicates that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive and potentially challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low days on market suggests a hot real estate market that may favor sellers over buyers.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy score ranking it at the 68th percentile, indicating a deeper professional talent pool than many of its peers. This makes the city more suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that rely on a knowledgeable workforce. However, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

In conclusion, Providence-Warwick offers a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, which are positives for businesses considering relocation or expansion. However, the city's high cost of living and tight labor market, characterized by low unemployment and moderate wage growth, pose significant challenges, particularly in terms of attracting and retaining talent without incurring high labor costs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C+

POOR

43.7th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	4
Unemployment	20% weight	53
Wage Growth	15% weight	78
Cost of Living	12% weight	52
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	33
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Days on Market	5% weight	8
Office Economy	3% weight	22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-1.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+163.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, -8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, and its strong wage growth, at 6.14% year-over-year, ranking above average at 78th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.96% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 1.397% above the city's own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 1.56 is in the bottom tier, at 4th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.50%, ranking near the median at 53rd percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely tight nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this area, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may not be overly difficult, but there may still be some competition for skilled workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this metro area is 6.14%, ranking above average at 78th percentile. This fast wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to consider higher salary offers to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.35, based on $224 per square foot and $35.27 per hour, this city ranks near the median at 52nd percentile. However, the PSF is increasing by 1.8% year-over-year, which may impact affordability. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.08% year-over-year, ranking below average at 33rd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is shrinking, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area has increased by 163.12% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at 98th percentile. This surge in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.3%. This rapid sales pace, ranking in the bottom tier at 8th percentile, indicates a competitive market where homes are selling quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, the fast-paced market may make it challenging to find and secure a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in this metro area is below average, ranking at 22nd percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting headquarters decisions.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex economic environment with strong wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, but also a shrinking labor force and competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business decision-maker to factor in is the limited supply of skilled workers, which may impact hiring capacity and business expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C+

POOR

40.2th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	24
Unemployment	20% weight	45
Wage Growth	15% weight	14
Cost of Living	12% weight	88
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	67
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	24
Days on Market	5% weight	34
Office Economy	3% weight	58

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	57 days	median, -1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.36 ranking it in the 24th percentile, and its high cost of living affordability, with a score of 88th percentile. The labor demand is characterized by a mere 0.40% employment growth rate and a -2.201% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.40% and weekly hours deviation of -2.201% signal a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the labor market is not robust, with hours worked below trend. The labor demand composite score of 3.36 further reinforces this assessment, ranking the city in the 24th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.80% places the city near the median, ranking it in the 45th percentile. This rate indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that businesses may face some competition for talent, potentially driving up wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.25% is relatively stagnant, ranking the city in the 14th percentile. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers have limited bargaining power and purchasing power is not increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living score ranking it in the 88th percentile, San Antonio-New Braunfels is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The PSF of $173/sqft, which is decreasing by 5.0% year-over-year, combined with an average hourly earnings of $32.19/hr, results in a ratio of 5.37. This affordability makes the city attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.11% year-over-year, ranking the city in the 67th percentile. This slow but positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit at a modest pace. This growth provides a slight advantage for businesses looking to hire, as the labor pool is gradually increasing.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -12.00%, ranking the city in the 24th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.7%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 34th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

With an office economy score ranking it in the 58th percentile, San Antonio-New Braunfels has a moderately deep professional talent pool. This makes the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers, but it may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized professional or tech talent.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slowly expanding labor force, but its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk for decision-makers is the potential for a tightening housing supply, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and make it harder to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C+

POOR

40.2th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	10
Unemployment	20% weight	92
Wage Growth	15% weight	6
Cost of Living	12% weight	8
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	45
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	82
Days on Market	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	20

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+19.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	42 days	median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 2.60%. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis is -1.06% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.398%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate, and the slight increase in hours worked may be due to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis is 2.60%, ranking it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This tight labor market means that there is little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this city, it may be necessary to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis is +0.36%, which is in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. This could impact the overall consumer demand in the local economy.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis has a cost of living score in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, with a PSF of $168/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $32.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.12. The PSF has increased by 5.0% year-over-year, making the city less affordable. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis is growing at a rate of -0.76% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 45th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply means that the pool of potential employees is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Indianapolis has increased by 19.68% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals that developer confidence is high, and future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve. However, this trend needs to be sustained to have a significant impact on the city's overall affordability.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.7%, ranking it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, indicating a slower and more buyer-friendly market. For a worker relocating to this city, this could make it easier to find and purchase a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis is below average, ranking it at the 20th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements.

In conclusion, Indianapolis offers a unique combination of a tight labor market and relatively low wage growth, which could be both a challenge and an opportunity for businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the city's low labor demand and shrinking labor force supply, which could limit the potential for business expansion and growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C+

POOR

38.2th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	34
Unemployment	20% weight	18
Wage Growth	15% weight	42
Cost of Living	12% weight	17
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	98
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	60
Days on Market	5% weight	2
Office Economy	3% weight	62

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+5.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	25 days	median, -3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 38.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.68 ranking it in the 34th percentile, and its high cost of living, with a ratio of $497/sqft to $45.89/hr, ranking it in the 17th percentile. The labor force growth rate of +2.87% YoY is a notable exception, ranking in the 98th percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -0.44% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.650% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are below trend. This suggests that businesses may not face intense competition for labor, but it also indicates a slower economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking it in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +3.53%, ranking it in the 42nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and workers have moderate purchasing power. The wage growth is not stagnant, but it is not exceptionally high either.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living ratio of $497/sqft to $45.89/hr, ranking it in the 17th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF is falling -1.6% YoY, but the city still ranks low in affordability. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living may deter workers from relocating to the area without compensation.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of +2.87% YoY, ranking it in the 98th percentile, indicating an expanding labor force supply. This means that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent. The expanding labor force also suggests that the city has a strong attraction and retention rate for workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is increasing by +5.64% YoY, ranking it in the 60th percentile, indicating an expanding housing supply. This suggests that the city is investing in new housing, which may improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 25 days, with a -3.9% YoY change, ranking it in the 2nd percentile, indicating a very competitive market. This means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market may require businesses to provide relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking it in the 62nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may not be as suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which may require a different type of workforce.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a highly educated and growing labor force, but it also presents challenges such as a high cost of living and a competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, due to the city's relatively high cost of living and tight labor market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C

VERY POOR

36.9th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	42
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	74
Cost of Living	12% weight	35
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	12
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	34
Days on Market	5% weight	46
Office Economy	3% weight	0

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+5.7%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-2.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-9.6%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
56 days
median, +5.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.13. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average unemployment rate of 4.90% and its above-average wage growth of +5.74% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is -0.12% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.210% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face a challenging environment for expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 4.90%, which is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is +5.74%, which is above average, ranking in the 74th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs are rising quickly, which may be a challenge for employers. However, it also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score that ranks in the 35th percentile, with a PSF of $337/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.50/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.49. The city's PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year, which is a key driver of its affordability. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, ranking in the 12th percentile. This decline in labor force growth indicates that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is falling -9.55% year-over-year, ranking in the 34th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.7%. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, with homes taking slightly longer to sell. However, the market remains relatively competitive, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a professional and office worker share that ranks in the 0th percentile, with a composite score of 0.16. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and rising labor costs, which may be challenging for expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's declining labor force growth, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses should carefully consider the potential challenges and opportunities in this market before making a location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C

VERY POOR

36.6th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	20
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	56
Cost of Living	12% weight	67
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	59
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	26
Days on Market	5% weight	78
Office Economy	3% weight	26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-11.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, +10.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and unemployment metrics. The labor demand composite score of 3.28, combining a -0.73% employment growth rate and a -0.398% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with an unemployment rate of 4.30%, suggests significant challenges in the local job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.73% and weekly hours deviation of -0.398% from trend indicate a contraction in labor demand, suggesting that the city is experiencing a period of job losses and reduced working hours. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, implying that businesses may face a surplus of labor rather than a shortage. The labor demand composite score of 3.28 further reinforces this assessment, ranking below average at the 20th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this market may find it easier to staff positions due to the available workforce, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The high unemployment rate suggests that the market is not tight, giving employers more flexibility in hiring and potentially reducing wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.24% is near the median, ranking at the 56th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a pace that is neither extremely fast nor stagnant. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, which could have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.03, based on $221/sqft (which is falling at a rate of -1.3% YoY) compared to $36.68/hr, Baltimore-Columbia-Towson ranks above average in affordability at the 67th percentile. This means that the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without the need for significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.01% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking at the 59th percentile. This minimal growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is barely expanding, suggesting a potential structural headwind for hiring in the future. However, the impact of this slow growth may be mitigated by the current surplus of labor.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -11.88%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline suggests that developer confidence may be waning, and the future housing supply may not keep pace with demand, potentially leading to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for a median of 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%. This increase, ranking at the 78th percentile, suggests a slower market where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, potentially easing the transition.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, with a composite score of 1.66, ranks below average at the 26th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these areas. This suggests that Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is less suited for businesses requiring a strong presence of tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, but may be more accommodating to industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, the Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate pace of wage growth, which could attract talent and support local consumer demand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the challenging labor market, characterized by high unemployment and contracting labor demand, which may impact hiring strategies and local economic growth prospects.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C

VERY POOR

36.3th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	33
Wage Growth	15% weight	68
Cost of Living	12% weight	71
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	6
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	86
Days on Market	5% weight	18
Office Economy	3% weight	32

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.9%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+5.3%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-3.0%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**-2.5%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**+35.7%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**30 days**	median, +3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score heavily influenced by its poor labor demand and labor force growth metrics, which are both in the bottom tier. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.95% employment growth rate and a -0.771% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This is further exacerbated by a labor force growth rate of -2.52%, indicating a shrinking labor pool.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.95% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.771% from the city's own 12-month baseline, combining for a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier. This signals a clear contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth rate indicates that the city is experiencing job losses.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 3.90%, ranking in the 33rd percentile, which suggests a below-average but not extremely tight labor market. This implies that while there may be some competition for talent, it is still possible for businesses to hire without extreme wage pressure. However, the market is not so slack as to make hiring effortless.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the area is +5.31% year-over-year, placing it in the 68th percentile, indicating above-average wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. The relatively fast wage growth could attract high-skilled workers but may also increase operational costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $310/sqft to $44.92/hr, and the price per square foot falling -3.1% year-over-year, Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks in the 71st percentile for affordability. This means the city is more affordable than most of its peers, which could be a significant talent attraction advantage without needing wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is shrinking at a rate of -2.52% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding suitable candidates due to this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The city has seen a +35.66% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, placing it in the top tier. This significant increase signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. The rise in building permits is a positive indicator for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria are currently sitting on the market for a median of 30 days, with a +3.5% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 18th percentile. This suggests a relatively slow market, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing, as homes are not selling as quickly as in hotter markets.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks in the 32nd percentile, indicating a below-average depth of professional talent pool. This suggests the city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers a unique combination of above-average wage growth and improving affordability, which could attract talent without necessitating significant wage premiums. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the shrinking labor force and poor labor demand, which could severely limit hiring capacity and business expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

C

VERY POOR

36.0th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	40
Unemployment	20% weight	16
Wage Growth	15% weight	46
Cost of Living	12% weight	31
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	44
Days on Market	5% weight	32
Office Economy	3% weight	36

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	N/A	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	N/A	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-1.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, +3.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36th out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of mediocre labor demand and cost of living metrics. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 3.99 and its below-average cost of living percentile rank of 31. Specifically, the combination of -0.01% employment growth and +0.300% weekly hours deviation signals a labor market with minimal genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is -0.01%, indicating a slight contraction, while the weekly hours deviation is +0.300%, suggesting that remaining workers are absorbing a slightly higher workload. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where the remaining workforce is taking on more hours, rather than a genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

Although the unemployment rate is not available, the city's percentile rank of 16 suggests a relatively high unemployment rate, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.59%, which is near the median. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 31, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is relatively expensive, particularly given its PSF of $220/sqft and hourly earnings of $36.81, resulting in a ratio of 5.98. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is not available, but its percentile rank of 50 suggests a near-median growth rate. This implies that the workforce supply is neither expanding nor contracting significantly, which may have a neutral impact on hiring capacity.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -1.45%, indicating a slight tightening of housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, potentially leading to increased competition for housing and higher costs for workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.1%. This indicates a slowing market, which may make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they will have more time to find a home.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 36, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a below-average share of professional and office workers. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles.

In conclusion, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin offers businesses a labor market with some slack and moderate wage growth, but its high cost of living and tightening housing supply may pose significant challenges for attracting and accommodating talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

C

VERY POOR

34.5th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	52
Unemployment	20% weight	35
Wage Growth	15% weight	14
Cost of Living	12% weight	15
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	14
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	46
Days on Market	5% weight	86
Office Economy	3% weight	14

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-1.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	41 days	median, +7.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 4.50% and stagnant wage growth of +1.25% year-over-year. The city's economic character is defined by its near-median labor demand, with employment growth of +0.57% and weekly hours deviation of -0.456%, indicating a moderate expansion. The combination of these metrics suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.57% and weekly hours deviation of -0.456% indicate a moderate expansion, but the combination of these metrics suggests that the labor market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This signals that while jobs are being added, hours are not running above trend, which may indicate some level of inefficiency in the labor market. The labor demand composite score of 4.64 ranks near the median at 52nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.50% is below average, ranking at the 35th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.25% is stagnant, ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating that labor costs are not rising rapidly. This slow wage growth means that employers may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but it also implies that workers may not have strong purchasing power. The stagnant wage growth may be a concern for businesses relying on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $344/sqft and hourly earnings of $38.27, resulting in a ratio of 8.99, ranks at the 15th percentile, indicating that it is relatively expensive. This means that the city may not have a talent attraction advantage, as workers may require wage premiums to afford the cost of living. The lack of affordability may be a challenge for businesses trying to attract and retain talent.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -1.68%, ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating that the labor force is contracting. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may create a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. The contracting labor force may limit the city's ability to support growing businesses.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -1.37%, ranking at the 46th percentile, indicating that housing supply is not expanding rapidly. This signals that the city's housing market may be tightening, which could lead to affordability concerns and challenges for workers relocating to the area. The slow growth in building permits may limit the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 41 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.9%, ranking at the 86th percentile, indicating a slower market. This means that homes are sitting on the market for longer, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The slower market may be beneficial for workers, but it may also indicate a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 1.26, ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This means that the city may not be well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. The city's economy may be more suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers a relatively tight labor market and a slow pace of life, but the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the lack of affordability and the contracting labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support growing businesses. The stagnant wage growth and relatively expensive cost of living may also create challenges for businesses trying to attract and retain talent. Overall, the city's economic character is defined by its moderate expansion and lack of genuine demand expansion, making it a challenging location for businesses that require a deep talent pool and rapid growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C

VERY POOR

33.4th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	14
Unemployment	20% weight	49
Wage Growth	15% weight	18
Cost of Living	12% weight	21
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	47
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	64
Days on Market	5% weight	66
Office Economy	3% weight	16

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+7.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	32 days	median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.10, indicating a struggling job market. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, with employment growth at -0.86% year-over-year and wage growth at +1.33% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.86% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.000% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city's job market actually shrinking. The scenario suggests that businesses may face a tough time finding skilled workers, but may also have less competition for talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.70%, ranking near the median at the 49th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face moderate competition for talent, but should still be able to find qualified workers without excessive wage pressure. However, the near-median ranking suggests that the city is not particularly competitive in terms of labor market tightness.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.33%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth suggests that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but may also struggle to attract top talent with competitive salaries.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score ranking at the 21st percentile, with a PSF of $227/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.46/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.23, which is below average. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, ranking below average in terms of affordability. However, the low percentile rank indicates that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of -0.58% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which could create a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the city. As a result, businesses may face increasing competition for a dwindling pool of skilled workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +7.85% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and make the city more attractive to relocating workers. However, the current pace of growth may not be sufficient to meet demand, and the city's affordability challenges may persist.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is currently 32 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.3%, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, with homes taking longer to sell, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a weakening demand for housing, which could have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, indicating a shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city may not be well-suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized knowledge workers, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses with less specialized labor needs, such as logistics or manufacturing companies.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers a relatively low-cost business environment, but with significant challenges in terms of labor demand and wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering relocation to this city is the shrinking labor pool and stagnant wage growth, which could create significant challenges for hiring and expansion. As a result, businesses should carefully weigh the pros and cons of relocating to Milwaukee-Waukesha and consider strategies to attract and retain top talent in a competitive labor market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C

VERY POOR

33.2th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	44
Unemployment	20% weight	39
Wage Growth	15% weight	10
Cost of Living	12% weight	29
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	41
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	28
Days on Market	5% weight	44
Office Economy	3% weight	12

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-11.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	34 days	median, +3.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of mediocre labor demand and constrained affordability. The city's economic character is most defined by its low wage growth, at +0.54% year-over-year, and its below-average cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.41. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for both employers and employees.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.27% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.495% below trend, indicating a labor demand composite score of 4.18, which is near the median. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not increasing despite modest job growth. The labor market is not experiencing significant contraction, but rather a stable, unremarkable period.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 3.80%, ranking below average at the 39th percentile. This suggests a moderately tight labor market with some slack, making it somewhat challenging for businesses to hire, but not extremely difficult. As a result, businesses may face moderate wage pressure when trying to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.54%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth implies a flat labor cost environment for employers, but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which may impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living percentile rank of 29, indicating that it is below average in terms of affordability, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.41. The city's PSF is $214/sqft, which is decreasing by -0.5% year-over-year, relative to hourly earnings of $39.59. This suggests that the city is not particularly attractive for talent without wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is contracting at a rate of -0.90% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is decreasing, making it more challenging for businesses to find talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -11.74%, indicating a tightening housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of housing is not expanding to meet demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 34 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.0%. This indicates a moderately competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are taking slightly longer to sell. However, the market is still relatively accessible, with homes selling within a reasonable timeframe.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 0.96, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office or professional workers, making the city less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a stable, albeit unremarkable, labor market with moderate wage pressure and a relatively high cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the stagnant wage growth and shrinking labor pool, which may limit the city's attractiveness for talent and hinder businesses' ability to find and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C

VERY POOR

33.1th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	80
Cost of Living	12% weight	60
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	16
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	62
Days on Market	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	8

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+6.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-2.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+7.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **47 days** median, +6.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking in the 33.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 1.50. This city's economic character is most defined by its negative employment growth rate of -2.81% and high wage growth rate of +6.37%. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -2.81%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.489% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for talent, but also a potentially weaker local economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.80%, which is relatively high, ranking in the 10th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also suggests that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is +6.37%, which is relatively fast, ranking in the 80th percentile. This signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses may need to factor in higher wage costs, but also benefit from a more affluent local workforce.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score that ranks in the 60th percentile, with a PSF of $310/sqft and average hourly earnings of $41.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.40. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, but still competitive, with a slightly above-average affordability score. This may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, but the city's affordability is still relatively attractive.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -1.57% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor force supply. This suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by +7.12% year-over-year, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This signals that developer confidence is rising, and future housing affordability may improve, making it easier for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.8%. This suggests a slowing market, ranking in the 74th percentile, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this also indicates a potential shift in the balance of power between buyers and sellers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 0.68, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities. While the city's high wage growth and expanding housing supply are attractive, the declining labor force and relatively expensive cost of living may pose significant risks for businesses. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the city's limited labor force growth, which may hinder hiring capacity and business expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

Richmond

Richmond

C

VERY POOR

32.4th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	57
Wage Growth	15% weight	36
Cost of Living	12% weight	23
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	39
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	48
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	28

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-0.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, -2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 32.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its weak labor demand and expensive cost of living. The labor demand composite score of 2.27, combining a -0.87% employment growth rate and a +0.807% weekly hours deviation, suggests a contraction in job market activity. This is further exacerbated by a cost of living ratio of 6.44, with PSF at $232/sqft and hourly earnings at $36.00/hr, ranking in the 23rd percentile for affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.87% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating +0.807% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze, indicating a challenging job market. The labor demand composite score of 2.27 falls in the bottom tier, at the 8th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.40%, ranking in the 57th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This suggests that while the market is not overly tight, it is also not excessively loose, with some room for hiring but without significant wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in Richmond, this means a moderate level of difficulty in finding talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Richmond is +3.00% year-over-year, ranking below average in the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. However, this growth rate may not be sufficient to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Richmond's cost of living, with a PSF of $232/sqft and hourly earnings of $36.00/hr, results in a ratio of 6.44, ranking in the 23rd percentile for affordability. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 2.2% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -0.93% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding and retaining talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Richmond is decreasing by -0.85% year-over-year, suggesting a tightening of the housing supply. This decrease signals potential future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, which could impact the city's attractiveness to businesses and talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Richmond is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.7%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decreasing trend suggests some normalization in the market.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share, with a composite score of 1.68, ranks in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may be more appropriate for industries with fewer specialized roles.

The Richmond metro area offers a business a moderate labor market with some challenges in finding and retaining talent, largely due to its expensive cost of living and contracting labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, driven by the tightening housing supply and decreasing labor pool, which could impact the city's attractiveness and competitiveness in the long term.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C-

CRITICAL

31.7th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	18
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	22
Cost of Living	12% weight	46
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	55
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	30
Days on Market	5% weight	90
Office Economy	3% weight	44

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-11.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	38 days	median, +8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is in the bottom tier, and its cost of living, which is near the median. Specifically, the labor demand composite score is 3.25, ranking in the 18th percentile, and the cost of living ratio is 5.02, with a PSF of $183/sqft and hourly earnings of $36.47.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.75% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.730% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may not face significant competition for labor, but it also implies a weaker local economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 4.40%, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, but it also suggests that local consumer demand may be weaker. With an unemployment rate above the national average, businesses may have a larger pool of potential employees to draw from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.73%, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating below-average wage growth. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living ratio of 5.02, with a PSF of $183/sqft and hourly earnings of $36.47, ranking in the 46th percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a PSF that is decreasing by -0.5% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of -0.07% year-over-year, ranking in the 55th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, albeit slowly, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the long term. As the labor force shrinks, businesses may face increasing competition for a smaller pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is decreasing by -11.39% year-over-year, ranking in the 30th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could pose a risk to businesses looking to attract and retain talent, as a limited housing supply can drive up costs and reduce the quality of life for employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.6%, ranking in the 90th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this slower market may also indicate a decrease in demand for housing, which could have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 2.48, ranking in the 44th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slower housing market, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and relocation. However, the city's labor demand contraction, declining labor force growth, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks to businesses looking to establish or expand operations in the area, and decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when making a location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

C-

CRITICAL

30.4th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	26
Unemployment	20% weight	84
Wage Growth	15% weight	34
Cost of Living	12% weight	2
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	0
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	12
Days on Market	5% weight	6
Office Economy	3% weight	10

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-7.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-21.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	30 days	median, -3.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.43, and its extremely low affordability, with a cost of living percentile rank of 2. The labor demand is further exacerbated by a -0.62% employment growth rate and a -0.775% weekly hours deviation from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an employment growth rate of -0.62% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.775% from its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This metric ranks below average at the 26th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 3.60%, which is relatively low, ranking at the 84th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to wage pressure. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.67%, which is below average, ranking at the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit slowly. This could be a relatively stable environment for businesses, but may not be attractive for workers seeking rapid wage growth.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living percentile rank of 2, indicating that it is extremely expensive relative to its peers, with a PSF of $224/sqft and an earnings ratio of $32.68/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.85. This low affordability score means that the city is at a disadvantage for talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -6.97% year-over-year, ranking at the 0th percentile. This significant decline in labor force supply indicates a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain talent. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to upskill existing workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has decreased by -21.72% year-over-year, ranking at the 12th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This could exacerbate the existing labor force contraction and high cost of living.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 30 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.2%. This relatively fast market, ranking at the 6th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find housing. However, this may also contribute to the city's affordability issues and tightening housing supply.

Office Economy

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a professional and office worker share of 0.80, ranking at the 10th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting. However, the city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with low unemployment, but this is offset by significant challenges, including low labor demand, high cost of living, and a contracting labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the high cost of living and limited labor force growth, which may require significant investments in wage premiums and training programs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

C-

CRITICAL

26.3th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	6
Unemployment	20% weight	65
Wage Growth	15% weight	24
Cost of Living	12% weight	27
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	24
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	4
Days on Market	5% weight	38
Office Economy	3% weight	6

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.0%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-31.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **38 days** median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 26.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 2.11, and its below-average wage growth of 1.79% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.85% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.999%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation. The slight increase in weekly hours may suggest a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the workload of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.00%, ranking it at the 65th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new employees. However, the unemployment rate is not extremely low, which could help mitigate some of the wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Louisville-Jefferson County is 1.79%, ranking it below average at the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace. Workers in the area will see some improvement in their purchasing power, but it may not be enough to drive significant economic growth.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score ranking it at the 27th percentile, with a PSF of $180/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $31.09/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.79. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The lack of affordability may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is declining at a rate of -1.41% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit new employees.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by 31.15% year-over-year. This sharp decline indicates that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 38 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively slow pace suggests that the housing market is not extremely competitive, making it accessible for workers relocating to the area.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Louisville-Jefferson County ranks at the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and may not be ideal for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market and moderate wage growth, but its low labor demand, declining labor force, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited ability to accommodate a growing workforce, making it essential to carefully consider the potential challenges and limitations of operating in this market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

D

EMERGENCY

19.3th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	16
Unemployment	20% weight	4
Wage Growth	15% weight	2
Cost of Living	12% weight	33
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	49
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	20
Days on Market	5% weight	36
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.8%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**-0.2%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.4%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**-0.5%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**-15.1%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**59 days**	median, -1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 19.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.14. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.80% and stagnant wage growth of -0.16% YoY. These metrics signal a challenging labor market for businesses looking to hire and retain talent.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is -0.37% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating 0.645% above the city's own 12-month baseline. However, the combination of these metrics signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze. This suggests that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, which is relatively low, indicating a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that there may be upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The YoY wage growth rate in Jacksonville is -0.16%, indicating stagnant wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing. The stagnant wage growth may make it difficult for businesses to attract and retain talent, as workers may be looking for better compensation packages.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living percentile rank of 33, with a PSF of $218/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.14/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.03. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The affordability of the city means that businesses may be able to attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of -0.49% YoY, indicating a contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of available workers is shrinking, which may create a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Jacksonville is decreasing by 15.07% YoY, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand. Businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tight housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 59 days, with a YoY decrease of 1.7%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The competitive market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

Jacksonville has an office economy percentile rank of 50, with a share of professional and office workers of 2.74. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may be less suited for businesses that require a large pool of industrial or logistics workers.

The city of Jacksonville presents a challenging labor market for businesses, with low unemployment and stagnant wage growth. The biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tight labor market, which may require significant investment in talent attraction and retention strategies. Despite this, the city's relatively affordable cost of living and moderate office economy may make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses.